Himaayah Schools
MADRASAH

FREE GUIDE

إِنَّا لِلَّهِ وَإِنَّا إِلَيْهِ رَاجِعُونَ

"Indeed we belong to Allah, and to Him we will return." (al-Baqarah 2:156)

The Fiqh of Janāzah

What to do when a Muslim dies, in the Mālikī school: washing, shrouding, the funeral prayer, burial, grief and the rights of the deceased.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

> كُلُّ نَفْسٍ ذَائِقَةُ الْمَوْتِ ۗ وَإِنَّمَا تُوَفَّوْنَ أُجُورَكُمْ يَوْمَ الْقِيَامَةِ
>
> **“Every soul will taste death, and you will only be given your full reward on the Day of Resurrection.”**
>
> Āl ʿImrān 3:185.

Death comes to every family. When it comes, the people around the deceased have duties to fulfil quickly and correctly: washing, shrouding, praying over and burying the Muslim, settling the debts, and comforting the bereaved. These are a **farḍ kifāyah**: an obligation on the community, which is lifted from all when some carry it out, and which all share the sin of if it is neglected.

This guide explains what to do, step by step, according to the school of **Imām Mālik**, from the last moments of life to the visiting of graves. It is written for families, students and those who wash and bury the dead in their community.

A guide for calm hands

Many people meet these rulings for the first time on the day of a death, in grief. Read this guide now, while you are calm, and keep it with your family’s important papers.

Where the scholars of the school differ, the well-known view is given. Follow the imām or the experienced washers in your community where they follow another accepted view.

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Part 1 Before death

Visiting the sick

Visiting the sick is a right of the Muslim on his brother (al-Bukhārī 1240, Muslim 2162). “Whoever visits a sick person is in the harvest of Paradise until he returns” (Muslim, 2568). Sit briefly, make duʿāʾ for him, and give him hope. The Prophet ﷺ would say: “Lā baʾs, ṭahūrun in shāʾ Allāh”: no harm, it is a purification, if Allah wills (al-Bukhārī, 3616).

The will (waṣiyyah) and debts

“It is not right for a Muslim who has something to bequeath to spend two nights without his will written down with him” (al-Bukhārī 2738, Muslim 1627). A Muslim should write down:

- **Debts he owes and debts owed to him**, and any trusts (amānāt) he holds for others. Debts come before everything else from his estate.

- **A bequest (waṣiyyah)**, if he wishes, of **up to one third** of his estate, to people who do not inherit or to good causes. “One third, and one third is a lot” (al-Bukhārī 2742, Muslim 1628). There is no bequest to an heir (Abū Dāwūd 2870, at-Tirmidhī 2120).
- Wishes about his funeral that agree with the Sunnah, such as being buried simply in a Muslim graveyard.

The last moments

- **Talqīn:** gently prompt the dying person to say “Lā ilāha illā Allāh”, without pressing or repeating it after he has said it. “Prompt your dying ones: lā ilāha illā Allāh” (Muslim, 916). “Whoever’s last words are lā ilāha illā Allāh will enter Paradise” (Abū Dāwūd, 3116).
- Turn him towards the **qiblah**, on his right side if possible, and keep the place calm and clean. Those present should say only good, “for the angels say āmīn to what you say” (Muslim, 919).
- Make duʿāʾ for him quietly. (Imām Mālik disliked turning the deathbed into a gathering for recitation; other schools recommend reciting Sūrat Yā Sīn.)

Part 2 At the moment of death

When the soul leaves, the Prophet ﷺ closed Abū Salamah’s eyes and said: “When the soul is taken, the sight follows it,” and prayed: “O Allah, forgive Abū Salamah, raise his rank among the rightly guided…” (Muslim, 920). Then:

1. **Close the eyes** and say: “Bismillāh wa ʿalā millati rasūlillāh”, with duʿāʾ for the deceased.
2. **Tie the jaw** gently with a strip of cloth over the head, and soften the joints while the body is still warm.
3. **Remove his clothes** carefully and **cover the whole body** with a sheet. Place it on a raised surface, away from the ground.
4. **Inform** family, friends and the imām. Announcing a death so that people pray is permitted; the Prophet ﷺ announced the death of the Najāshī (al-Bukhārī, 1245). Loud public wailing announcements are not.
5. **Hasten** the washing, prayer and burial: “Hurry with the funeral” (al-Bukhārī 1315, Muslim 944). Do not delay it for distant relatives unless the delay is short.
6. **Begin settling his debts** from his estate as soon as possible: “The believer’s soul is suspended by his debt until it is paid for him” (at-Tirmidhī, 1078).

Part 3 Washing the deceased (ghusl)

Washing the Muslim who has died is a farḍ kifāyah in the well-known view of the school. The best guide is the ḥadīth of **Umm ʿAṭiyyah**, who washed the Prophet’s ﷺ daughter Zaynab: “Wash her three, five or more times if you see the need, with water and lote leaves (sidr), and put camphor in the last washing… Begin with her right side and the places of wuḍūʾ” (al-Bukhārī 1253, 1255; Muslim 939).

Who washes

Deceased	Who washes, in order
A man	His wife first in the Mālikī school, then the closest of his male relatives, then other men.
A woman	Her husband first in the school, then the closest of her female relatives, then other women.
A young child	A man or a woman may wash a child who is too young to be desired.
No one of the same sex present	A man with no man or wife present is washed by a maḥram woman, fully covered; if there is no maḥram, a woman gives him tayammum to the elbows. The same applies to a woman with no woman or husband present.

The washer should be trustworthy, keep silent about anything unpleasant he sees, and speak of the good. “Whoever washes a Muslim and conceals what he sees, Allah forgives him forty times” (al-Ḥākim).

How to wash, step by step

1. Prepare clean water (lukewarm is fine), soap or sidr, camphor, gloves or cloths, towels and a sheet. Only the washer and helpers should be present.
2. Place the body on a raised bench, facing the qiblah if possible. **Keep the ʿawrah covered** with a cloth throughout: from the navel to the knees for a man.
3. Make the **intention** of washing the deceased. Gently **press the abdomen** to expel what is in it.
4. With a cloth wrapped on the left hand, **wash the private parts** (istinjāʾ) under the cover, without looking. Then change the cloth.
5. Give him **wuḍūʾ** as for the prayer, gently cleaning the mouth and nose with a wet cloth.
6. Wash the **head and beard** with water and soap or sidr, then the **right side** of the body from top to bottom, front and back, turning him gently on his left; then the **left side**. This is one washing.
7. Repeat to make **three** washings, or five or seven if needed for cleanliness, always an odd number. Add **camphor** or perfume to the last water.
8. Dry the body with a towel. For a woman, her hair is **braided in three plaits** placed behind her (al-Bukhārī, 1262).
9. If something comes out after washing, wash that place only; the washing is not repeated.

For students

Is the ghusl farḍ or sunnah? Two views are reported in the school; the well-known one is that it is a farḍ kifāyah.

Spouses may wash each other in the school; Asmāʾ bint ʿUmays washed Abū Bakr at his instruction (al-Muwaṭṭaʾ), and ʿAlī is reported to have washed Fāṭimah.

Part 4 Shrouding (kafan)

The shroud should be **white**, clean, and from the deceased's own wealth before debts. ʿĀʾishah said: "The Messenger of Allah ﷺ was shrouded in three white cotton cloths from Yemen, with no shirt and no turban among them" (al-Bukhārī 1264, Muslim 941). "Wear white clothes… and shroud your dead in them" (Abū Dāwūd 3878, at-Tirmidhī 994).

	Shroud
A man	Three white wrappings (lafāʾif) is the Sunnah. The school also permits up to five, including a shirt (qamīṣ) and a turban. An odd number is recommended.
A woman	Five pieces is common: a wrapper for the lower body, a shirt, a head cover (khimār) and two wrappings. The school permits up to seven.
A child	One to three cloths.
The one in iḥrām	In the school, his iḥrām ends with death and he is washed and shrouded like anyone else. The ḥadīth of the pilgrim left unperfumed with his head uncovered (al-Bukhārī 1265) is understood as particular to him; other schools apply it to every pilgrim.

Lay the wrappings one on top of the other, perfume them (ḥanūṭ), place the body on them, put perfume on the places of sujūd and the body's openings, then fold the right side of each wrapping over, then the left, and tie them at the head and feet. Untie the knots in the grave.

Part 5 The funeral prayer (ṣalāt al-janāzah)

"Whoever attends a funeral until he prays over it has a qīrāṭ, and whoever attends until it is buried has two qīrāṭs." He was asked: "What are the two qīrāṭs?" He said: "Like two great mountains" (al-Bukhārī 1325, Muslim 945).

Its pillars in the Mālikī school

Pillar	Detail
Intention	To pray over this deceased person.
Four takbīrs	Each takbīr is a pillar; raise the hands with the first only, in the well-known view.
Duʿāʾ for the deceased	After each takbīr. There is no recitation of al-Fātiḥah in the well-known view of the school.
One salām	Said a little aloud by the imām, to the right.
Standing	For the one who is able.

How to pray it

1. The imām stands level with the **middle of a man's body** and the **shoulders of a woman**. The people stand in rows behind him; three or more rows are recommended.
2. **First takbīr**, raising the hands: praise Allah, send ṣalāh on the Prophet ﷺ, then make duʿāʾ for the deceased.
3. **Second takbīr**: duʿāʾ for the deceased.
4. **Third takbīr**: duʿāʾ for the deceased.
5. **Fourth takbīr**: a short duʿāʾ for the deceased and the Muslims, then **one salām**.
6. If you join late, say the takbīr and follow the imām; after his salām, make up the missed takbīrs, before the body is lifted if you can.

> اللَّهُمَّ اغْفِرْ لَهُ وَارْحَمْهُ، وَعَافِهِ وَاعْفُ عَنْهُ، وَأَكْرِمْ نُزُلَهُ، وَوَسِّعْ مُدْخَلَهُ، وَاغْسِلْهُ بِالْمَاءِ وَالثَّلْجِ وَالْبَرَدِ، وَنَقِّهِ مِنَ الْخَطَايَا كَمَا نَقَّيْتَ الثَّوْبَ الْأَبْيَضَ مِنَ الدَّنَسِ
>
> **"O Allah, forgive him and have mercy on him, keep him safe and pardon him, honour his arrival and make wide his entrance, wash him with water, snow and hail, and cleanse him of sins as You cleanse a white garment of dirt."**
>
> Muslim (963). For a woman say: lahā, warḥamhā… (her).

> اللَّهُمَّ اغْفِرْ لِحَيِّنَا وَمَيِّتِنَا، وَشَاهِدِنَا وَغَائِبِنَا، وَصَغِيرِنَا وَكَبِيرِنَا، وَذَكَرِنَا وَأُنْثَانَا
>
> **"O Allah, forgive our living and our dead, those present and those absent, our young and our old, our men and our women."**
>
> Abū Dāwūd (3201), at-Tirmidhī (1024).

For a child, ask Allah to make him a reward and a treasure for his parents, an intercessor whose intercession is accepted. The school does not pray over the absent (ṣalāt al-ghāʾib) in its well-known view, and holds that the Prophet's ﷺ prayer over the Najāshī was particular to him.

Part 6 Carrying and burial

- **Carry the body quickly**, without running. “If it was righteous, it is good you are taking it to; if not, it is evil you are putting off your necks” (al-Bukhārī, 1315).
- In the Mālikī school, those walking go **in front of the bier**, as the Prophet ﷺ, Abū Bakr and ʿUmar did (al-Muwaṭṭaʾ); riders go behind. Walk in silence, reflecting; do not raise voices.
- Do not sit until the bier is placed on the ground (al-Bukhārī, 1310).
- **Women:** “We were forbidden to follow funerals, but it was not made strict on us” (al-Bukhārī 1278, Muslim 938). The school permits an elderly woman, and a close relative such as a mother or daughter, and dislikes it for young women.

The grave and the burial

1. The **laḥd** (a niche dug into the qiblah side of the grave) is better than a plain trench (shaqq) where the soil allows. The grave is made deep enough to protect the body.
2. Men lower the body, entering it from the foot of the grave if possible, saying: “**Bismillāh wa ʿalā millati rasūlillāh**” (Abū Dāwūd 3213, at-Tirmidhī 1046).
3. Lay the body on its **right side facing the qiblah**, untie the knots of the shroud, and close the niche with unbaked bricks, boards or stones.
4. Those present throw **three handfuls of soil**, then fill the grave. It is raised about a hand-span above the ground and may be marked with a stone.
5. After burial, stand at the grave and ask forgiveness and steadfastness for him: “Ask forgiveness for your brother and ask for him to be made firm, for he is now being questioned” (Abū Dāwūd, 3221).

It is forbidden to build over graves, plaster them or sit on them (Muslim, 970), and to take graves as places of prayer (al-Bukhārī 1330, Muslim 529).

Part 7 Grief, condolence and the rights of the deceased

Grief in Islām

Tears and sadness are mercy. When his son Ibrāhīm died, the Prophet ﷺ wept and said: “The eye weeps and the heart grieves, but we say only what pleases our Lord. We are saddened by your parting, O Ibrāhīm” (al-Bukhārī, 1303). What is forbidden is **wailing** (niyāḥah), striking the face, tearing clothes and words of objection to Allah’s decree (al-Bukhārī, 1294).

> اللَّهُمَّ أْجُرْنِي فِي مُصِيبَتِي، وَأَخْلِفْ لِي خَيْرًا مِنْهَا
>
> **“O Allah, reward me for my affliction and give me something better in its place.”**
>
> Said with “Innā lillāhi wa innā ilayhi rājiʿūn” (Muslim, 918). Umm Salamah said it when Abū Salamah died, and Allah gave her the Prophet ﷺ.

Mourning (iḥdād)

Relatives may mourn, by leaving adornment, for up to **three days**. A widow mourns her husband for **four months and ten days**, staying in her home and avoiding perfume, adornment and bright clothes (al-Bukhārī 1280, Muslim 1486), or until she gives birth if she is pregnant.

Condolence (taʿziyah)

Visit and comfort the family, in the days after the death. A good word is the Prophet's ﷺ: "To Allah belongs what He takes and to Him belongs what He gives, and everything with Him has an appointed time, so be patient and seek the reward" (al-Bukhārī 1284, Muslim 923). "Prepare food for the family of Jaʿfar, for what has befallen them has kept them busy" (Abū Dāwūd 3132, at-Tirmidhī 998): neighbours and relatives feed the bereaved family, not the reverse.

Customs to be careful about

The Companions counted gathering at the house of the deceased and the family preparing food for guests as a kind of wailing (Ibn Mājah, 1612). Scholars of the school warned against loading the bereaved family with costly gatherings, fixed ceremonies on set days, and expensive feasts. Keep the funeral simple, help the family, and give charity for the deceased instead.

What benefits the deceased

- **Duʿāʾ and seeking forgiveness** for him (al-Ḥashr 59:10).
- **Charity** given on his behalf (al-Bukhārī 1388, Muslim 1004).
- **Paying his debts**, and fulfilling his vows and his lawful bequest.
- **Ḥajj and ʿumrah** on his behalf, for one who has already performed his own.
- His own **ongoing charity, beneficial knowledge and righteous child** who prays for him (Muslim, 1631).

Visiting graves

"I forbade you from visiting graves; now visit them, for they remind you of the Hereafter" (Muslim 977; at-Tirmidhī 1054). On arrival say:

السَّلَامُ عَلَيْكُمْ أَهْلَ الدِّيَارِ مِنَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ وَالْمُسْلِمِينَ، وَإِنَّا إِنْ شَاءَ اللَّهُ بِكُمْ لَلَاحِقُونَ، أَسْأَلُ اللَّهَ لَنَا وَلَكُمُ الْعَافِيَةَ

“Peace be upon you, people of these dwellings, believers and Muslims. We will join you, if Allah wills. I ask Allah for well-being for us and for you.”

Muslim (975).

Part 8 Special cases

Case	Ruling in the school
The martyr killed in battle	Not washed, and buried in his clothes; in the well-known view of the school he is not prayed over, as with the martyrs of Uḥud (al-Bukhārī, 1343).
Other “martyrs” (the drowned, the one who dies of plague or of a stomach illness, the woman who dies in childbirth)	They have the reward of martyrs (al-Bukhārī 2829, Muslim 1914), but they are washed, shrouded and prayed over like anyone else.
A baby born dead, or a miscarriage	If the baby did not cry or show clear signs of life at birth, in the school it is not washed or prayed over: it is wrapped in a cloth and buried. If it cried or moved at birth and then died, it is treated like any deceased.
A body that cannot be washed	If washing would tear the body (burns, decay), water is poured over it; if even that is not possible, tayammum is given.
Only part of a body is found	In the school, it is washed and prayed over if most of the body is present.
Death at sea far from land	Washed, shrouded and prayed over, then weighted and placed in the sea.

Checklist What to do when a death happens

Done	Step
☐	Close the eyes, tie the jaw, cover the body, and make duʿāʾ.
☐	Inform the family, the imām and the washers. Get the death certified as required where you live.
☐	Gather the shroud, perfume, soap and water. Arrange the place of washing.
☐	Wash and shroud the body.
☐	Agree on the time and place of the funeral prayer, and the graveyard.
☐	Pray the funeral prayer, carry and bury.
☐	List the deceased's debts, trusts and will; begin paying debts from the estate.
☐	Divide the estate according to the Sharīʿah, with a scholar's help.
☐	Feed and support the bereaved family; keep away from costly customs.
☐	Keep making duʿāʾ and giving charity for the deceased.

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers follow the questions.

1. **The funeral rites are:**
   a) Sunnah only b) Farḍ kifāyah c) Farḍ on every Muslim d) Disliked

2. **What should the dying person be prompted to say?**
   a) Lā ilāha illā Allāh b) Sūrat al-Fātiḥah c) His will d) Nothing

3. **Up to how much of the estate may be bequeathed?**
   a) Half b) A quarter c) One third d) All of it

4. **In the school, who has first right to wash a man?**
   a) His son b) His wife c) The imām d) Any man

5. **How many washings are made?**
   a) An odd number: three, five or more b) Exactly two c) One only d) Ten

6. **The Prophet ﷺ was shrouded in:**
   a) One green cloth b) His own clothes c) A shirt and turban d) Three white cloths

7. **How many takbīrs are in the funeral prayer?**
   a) Two b) Three c) Four d) Five

8. **In the well-known Mālikī view, the funeral prayer has:**
   a) Al-Fātiḥah after the first takbīr b) Duʿāʾ after each takbīr, without al-Fātiḥah c) Rukūʿ d) Two salāms

9. Where does the imām stand for a woman?

a) At her feet b) At her head c) At her middle d) At her shoulders

10. How is the body laid in the grave?

a) On its back b) On its right side facing the qiblah c) Face down d) Sitting

11. A widow's iḥdād lasts:

a) Three days b) Forty days c) Four months and ten days d) One year

12. Who should cook for whom after a death?

a) Neighbours feed the bereaved family b) The family feeds the guests c) No one eats d) Only the imām

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	b) Farḍ kifāyah	7	c) Four
2	a) Lā ilāha illā Allāh	8	b) Duʿāʾ after each takbīr
3	c) One third	9	d) Her shoulders
4	b) His wife	10	b) Right side, facing the qiblah
5	a) An odd number	11	c) Four months and ten days
6	d) Three white cloths	12	a) Neighbours feed the family

For further study

- **Matn al-Akhḍarī** and **al-ʿAshmāwiyyah**, the chapters on janāʾiz, with a teacher.
- **Ar-Risālah** of Ibn Abī Zayd, the chapters on washing, shrouding and the funeral prayer.
- **Al-Muwaṭṭaʾ** of Imām Mālik, the Book of Funerals.

Duʿāʾ For our dead

رَبَّنَا اغْفِرْ لَنَا وَلِإِخْوَانِنَا الَّذِينَ سَبَقُونَا بِالْإِيمَانِ وَلَا تَجْعَلْ فِي قُلُوبِنَا غِلًّا لِّلَّذِينَ آمَنُوا رَبَّنَا إِنَّكَ رَءُوفٌ رَّحِيمٌ

"Our Lord, forgive us and our brothers who preceded us in faith, and put no resentment in our hearts towards those who believe. Our Lord, You are Kind and Merciful."

Al-Ḥashr 59:10.

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The last service we give each other.

This free guide from the Himaayah Madrasah explains, calmly and step by step, the rulings of death and burial according to the school of Imām Mālik.

- The will, debts and the last moments
- Washing and shrouding, step by step
- The funeral prayer and its duʿāʾs
- Burial, condolence and mourning
- Special cases and a checklist for families

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